

**40** PERCENT of the South Vietnamese population was estimated to be under the control or predominant influence of the Viet Cong in March 1964.



### **Jungle attack**

South Vietnamese forces and American soldiers come under attack by Viet Cong guerrillas while unloading supplies sent by the United States in 1964. At this point in the war, American casualties numbered a few hundred.

### **Decisive action**

Johnson had to respond. The president agreed to a massive expansion of counterinsurgency operations, a substantial increase in the size of the ARVN, and to dispatch more US aircraft and other military equipment. Yet he still shrunk from sending US combat troops into action. Nor would he authorize the bombing of North Vietnam as advocated by Air Force General Curtis LeMay. Khanh pressurized Johnson into taking further action. “The United States must take a firm course,” he told a Saigon press conference in August 1964, “so that North Vietnam knows it is not a “paper tiger.”

### **Strategy in the North**

While Johnson and his advisers debated what to do, the North Vietnamese leadership was also making major policy decisions. They concluded that Johnson had no intention of abandoning the US commitment to South Vietnam or of negotiating a settlement that would be acceptable to them. Accordingly, they decided to escalate the war by building up the insurgent forces in South Vietnam until they were strong enough to annihilate ARVN